

A WICKFIELD COMMUNITY CENTER DOSSIER

THE WICKFIELD EIGHT

CODENAMES · CASE FILES · ORIGINS

Amberlight · Bulwark · Circuit · Nightglass
Permafrost · Ricochet · The Latch · Wisp

Wickfield

Wickfield is a fictional city, built deliberately and directly on the bones of a real one: Chicago, Illinois. Every part of Wickfield described in this dossier — its lakefront, its elevated rail line, its winters, its patchwork of tight-knit neighborhoods — is drawn from Chicago's actual geography and character, filed down into an original setting for these stories rather than presented as the real place itself.

Like its real-world model, Wickfield sits along the shore of a Great Lake, and that lake shapes everything about how the city thinks of itself. Cold, lake-effect winters roll in hard and stay late; the wind off the water is famous enough that longtime residents plan their coats around it months in advance. A rail line known locally as the Line runs on elevated track through the heart of downtown before fanning out into the surrounding neighborhoods, an unmistakable echo of Chicago's own elevated trains, and its rattle overhead is as much a part of the city's soundtrack as traffic or gulls.

Downtown Wickfield rises in the same dense cluster of glass-and-steel towers that define any serious Great Lakes port city, but the dossier's real interest lies a few miles out from that skyline, in the working-class blocks where the Wickfield Eight actually live. These are neighborhoods of brick two-flats, corner stores that have outlasted three generations of ownership, dockyards and rail yards that still employ people whose grandparents worked the same jobs, and a fierce, specific pride of place that doesn't always show up on a map of the city's better-known landmarks. It's the Chicago of the neighborhood rather than the postcard — the version of the city where everyone recognizes everyone else's kids, and where an institution like a community center isn't a nice-to-have but genuine infrastructure.

That institution, for this story, is the Wickfield Community Center: an after-school program, a senior drop-in space, a free clinic table on Thursdays, and, as it turns out, the one fixed point that eight very different people all happened to already be orbiting before anyone thought to call them a team.

The Wickfield Eight

The Wickfield Eight did not begin as a team, and none of its eight members set out to join one. They began as eight separate people whose lives already orbited the same square block of the city — the Wickfield Community Center — for eight entirely unrelated reasons, long before anyone hung a name on what they'd eventually become. A dockworker who showed up most evenings to walk his cousin home. A security guard who'd worked the front doors for years and knew every regular by name. A nurse who ran informal health screenings on her days off. A barista from down the block, a bike courier who'd rewired the building's ancient WiFi as a favor, a restorer who'd quietly found a second home in a place that never asked about her past, a dropout engineer who couldn't leave a malfunctioning router alone, and a student who couldn't sit through a single one of the Center's evening programs without cracking a joke. Individually, none of them were looking for anything more than what the Center already gave them: a place that needed them, in small, ordinary ways.

What changed things was a fundraiser. The Center's annual fundraiser is its single largest event of the year — the night that keeps the after-school program running and the lights on through the next winter — and in the week leading up to it, the neighborhood started losing power in pieces. Rolling blackouts, block by block, each one a little closer to the Center than the last, with no explanation from the utility company and no pattern anyone could immediately make sense of. Ren Cruz noticed first, because noticing was her job; she'd worked the Center's doors long enough to know its rhythms, and the blackouts didn't fit any of them. She started asking questions, and it turned out she wasn't the only one who'd clocked that something was wrong.

What she found, piece by piece, was that most of the people already around the Center that week weren't quite as ordinary as their day jobs suggested. Some of them had never told anyone. Some of them hadn't fully told themselves. But with the fundraiser bearing down and the blackouts creeping closer by the night, eight people who already trusted this one building and, by extension, each other made the same decision independently: whatever was coming for Wickfield Community Center was going to have to go through them first.

It worked. The fundraiser happened, the lights stayed on where it counted, and the people responsible for the blackouts were pushed back — for that night, at least. What surprised all eight of them was what happened afterward: nobody drifted back to being eight separate regulars who happened to share a building. They kept showing up together instead, on purpose, for the same institution that had accidentally introduced them in the first place. Nobody voted on a name. "The Wickfield Eight" is just what the neighborhood started calling them, and it stuck the way names for the people who show up for you always do.



Amberlight

Sable Okafor

SABLE OKAFOR · NURSE

HISTORY

Sable Okafor was a working nurse before she was anything else, and that ordering matters to her. The radiant-light abilities arrived later — a resuscitation that shouldn't have worked, a hallway that filled with warm gold light no one present has ever fully agreed on the details of — and when the dust settled she found she could do with a gesture some of what she'd spent years doing with her hands and training. She didn't quit the hospital floor. She just started staying later.

She volunteers at the Wickfield Community Center on her days off, running informal health screenings and looking in on the elderly residents who don't always make it to a clinic. The instinct to fix people came first, long before the powers gave her more ways to do it, and everyone who knows her professionally and personally will tell you that's still the truest thing about her.

PERSONALITY

Sable is warm in a way that's immediately disarming, and she's built an entire professional identity around staying calm when everyone around her isn't. She reads a room for who's hurting — physically or otherwise — within seconds of walking into it, and she genuinely cannot leave that person unattended, even when it isn't her job, even when it costs her. That instinct has gotten her in over her head more than once. She wouldn't trade it, and she'd tell you so directly if you suggested otherwise.

TRAITS

Bedside Manner. A professional skill that translates directly into the field. She can calm or reassure someone in the middle of a crisis like it's just another shift.

Triage Instinct. Years on a hospital floor, now applied to combat wounds. She can judge how badly someone is hurt at a glance.

Can't Turn It Off. She has to at least try to help anyone in pain nearby, whether or not it's her job, whether or not it's wise.

POWERS

Warm Light. A soft wave of golden light, guided by hand into a touched or nearby ally, that mends injuries or restores their strength — and, in its best moments, clears away whatever else has been holding them back.

Radiant Lance. A focused lance of radiant light thrown at a target, especially punishing to anything that draws its own strength from shadow or darkness.

Aegis of Light. A shimmering barrier of light wrapped around herself or a nearby ally, turning aside the worst of what's about to hit them.



Bulwark

Marcus "Mo" Odom

MARCUS "MO" ODOM · DOCKWORKER

HISTORY

Mo Odom has been strong since before he could explain why. His mutation announced itself at thirteen, when he put his hand through a locker door without meaning to, and every year since has been an exercise in figuring out how much of himself to hold back. He dropped out of organized sports early — it wasn't fair to anyone, coaches included — and found dock work instead, where being strong is just useful, not a problem to be managed. He's good at it, and the crew has stopped asking how he lifts what he lifts.

He grew up two blocks from the Wickfield Community Center and has never really left its orbit. His younger cousin is enrolled in the after-school program there, and Mo shows up most evenings under the excuse of picking her up, though everyone including her knows he'd be there anyway. The neighborhood is small enough that he's quietly become its backstop — the guy people call when something needs to not fall down, or someone needs to not get hurt.

PERSONALITY

Mo is unhurried in a way that reads as calm right up until it doesn't. He thinks before he moves, weighs consequences out of long habit, and would rather de-escalate a fight than start one — not from fear, but because he's spent a decade learning exactly what he's capable of and doesn't take it lightly. He's a man of few words who means the ones he uses. The rare times his temper actually breaks, it takes people by surprise precisely because he's spent so long keeping it leashed — and once it's loose, he doesn't stop pulling punches until the fight's actually over.

TRAITS

Ironhide. Years of manual freight work move through him instinctively. Whenever a situation calls for lifting, hauling, or breaking something heavy, Mo does it the way he'd muscle another shipping crate onto a truck bed.

Unbreakable Will. Mo's sense of who he is and what he won't do isn't easily shaken. Fear, intimidation, and attempts to bend his mind slide off him without much effort.

Slow to Anger. Mo takes a moment to get moving in a fight — the first swing rarely finds its mark cleanly, because pulling his punches is second nature to him. But once he's landed one solid hit, that hesitation disappears completely, and everything that follows lands harder and truer.

POWERS

Mighty 1. A single, controlled blow that can send an opponent sprawling — and on an especially solid hit, throw them clear across the room into whatever, or whoever, happens to be standing behind them.

Mighty 2. A two-handed haymaker thrown with everything he has. Slower to wind up, but devastating on contact, capable of flattening anyone not built to take a direct hit.

Sturdy. Mo's frame simply absorbs punishment that would stagger anyone else. Blows that would drop another person barely slow him down.

Banging Heads. When two enemies make the mistake of standing shoulder to shoulder, Mo grabs one in each hand and brings their heads together in a single motion.



Circuit

Owen Park

OWEN PARK · ENGINEERING-SCHOOL DROPOUT

HISTORY

Owen Park left his engineering program two semesters short of a degree, for reasons that come down to money and burnout in roughly equal measure. He kept every habit the program gave him — the lab discipline, the compulsive tinkering, the inability to leave a malfunctioning system alone — and spent one very bad winter pouring all of it into a gauntlet blaster and a support drone, built in his bedroom on a budget that shouldn't have covered a tenth of what he made.

He rewired the Community Center's ancient WiFi for free not long after, mostly because Ricochet asked and he genuinely couldn't stand watching a router struggle. That favor is more or less how he ended up folded into the group — the one member of the team who solves problems by taking them apart on a workbench instead of hitting them, though the gauntlet's more than capable of the latter when it comes to it.

PERSONALITY

Owen is prickly about the dropout thing in a way that surfaces faster than he'd like, especially around anyone who leads with credentials. Give him a piece of unfamiliar tech under pressure, though, and the same insecurity turns into visible strain — his gear genuinely glitches more when he's rattled, which he insists is a coincidence. He talks to his equipment constantly, half habit and half genuine affection, and it's started responding in ways that are difficult to fully explain as just good engineering.

TRAITS

Dropout, Not a Washout. He never finished the degree. He didn't need to — his grasp of engineering and technology holds up regardless of the paper he doesn't have.

Overclocks Everything. His gear glitches when he's rattled, especially anything unfamiliar handled under pressure. A coincidence, he insists.

Built It Himself. He built it, so he can fix it — usually mid-fight, if he's given even a moment to work.

POWERS

Snap Shooting. A precise, HUD-aimed shot from his gauntlet blaster, fired at anything foolish enough to stay in his sightline.

Suppressive Fire. A raking line of blaster fire that catches everyone standing in its path at once and throws off their next move.

Stopping Power. A heavier blast from the gauntlet, built to physically shove its target backward on impact.

Field Drone. Owen's support drone deploys nearby and hovers over the fight, feeding tactical data to any ally close enough to make use of it.



Nightglass

Priya Anand

PRIYA ANAND · ART RESTORER

HISTORY

Priya Anand was restoring a 19th-century canvas that, according to every piece of provenance paperwork, had never left a private vault — until a hairline crack in the frame's backing revealed a shard of something that was never meant to be found, let alone touched. She touched it. She doesn't talk about what happened in the next several minutes, and the painting went back into storage with a very different restoration report than the client expected.

What she came out with was a bond to something old and dark that answers to her, mostly, and a set of abilities built around shadow and unseen things. She kept the day job — restoration work rewards exactly the kind of patience and attention to detail that made her good at noticing when something in a scene has been altered or hidden, mundane or otherwise. She's told almost no one at Wickfield the real story, and prefers it that way.

PERSONALITY

Priya is composed to the point of unreadable. She listens more than she speaks, prefers to solve a problem quietly before anyone else notices it existed, and treats her own history as exactly that — hers. She's not cold, exactly; she cares plainly and specifically about the handful of people she's let close, and the Community Center is one of the few places she's let herself be known at all. But pry at what's under the surface and she'll redirect, deflect, or simply leave the room, and she does not consider that a character flaw.

TRAITS

Restorer's Patience. Her actual profession, and it shows. She notices forgeries, tampering, and hidden details that everyone else walks right past.

Grew Up in the Dark. A side effect of the bond she carries: her eyes have adjusted to conditions most people struggle with, seeing clearly in darkness and low light, though a sudden burst of bright light leaves her just as disoriented as anyone else.

Keeps Secrets. Pressed to reveal anything personal, Priya shuts the conversation down rather than let anyone in.

POWERS

Umbral Lash. A lash of living shadow snaps out from her hand, striking at a distance and leaving the target's next move fumbled and uncertain.

Veil of Dusk. With a touch, Priya wraps herself or an ally in shadow thick enough to make them essentially invisible — untouchable by ranged attacks and unseen by normal sight until they act again.

Shadow Snare. Shadow reaches out to bind a target in place entirely, holding them fast until they can fight their way free.



Permafrost

Kai Nordahl

KAI NORDAHL · BARISTA, FORMER HOCKEY PLAYER

HISTORY

Kai Nordahl's ice powers came in during the last game of his last season, in the middle of a hard check into the boards that should have ended with a concussion and instead ended with a sheet of frost spreading across half the rink. The league didn't have a policy for that, so the decision got made for him: no more hockey, not competitively, not the way he'd planned his whole life around.

He works the counter at a coffee shop a few blocks from Wickfield Community Center now, which gives him something hockey never quite did — a fixed routine and a lot of familiar faces coming through the door every day. He's good at the job in a way that surprises people who meet the powers first: he remembers regulars' orders, their kids' names, who's had a rough week. It's the same attentiveness that used to read the ice, pointed somewhere new.

PERSONALITY

Kai presents as reserved, a little clipped, hard to get a read on — which is at least half literal, given what his powers do to a room's temperature when he's stressed. He's not actually cold; he's careful, still processing a loss most people never see because he doesn't talk about the hockey thing. What warmth he has comes out sideways, in remembered details and small kindnesses rather than open sentiment, and the people who've been on the other end of it know exactly how much it's worth.

TRAITS

Former Hockey Player. A career's worth of ice-honed footwork, still very much intact. Balance and rough contact rarely bother him.

Cold Front. Warmth and vulnerability come out sideways with Kai, if they come out at all. He reads as icy even when he doesn't mean to.

Knows Everybody's Order. Working the counter has made him a walking directory of the neighborhood — faces, names, and the gossip that goes with them.

POWERS

- Elemental Blast.** A blast of concentrated cold thrown at a distant target, enough to slow them where they stand.
- Elemental Burst.** The same cold energy, widened into a burst that catches everyone standing near the point of impact.
- Elemental Push.** A stronger blast that both freezes and physically shoves its target backward, hard enough to knock them off their feet if they collide with something on the way down.
- Ice Slide.** Kai lays a sheet of ice beneath his own feet and slides across it, covering far more ground in a straight line than a normal stride would allow.



Ricochet

Dani Reyes

DANI REYES · STUDENT, EX-GYMNAST

HISTORY

Dani Reyes was three weeks out from a regional gymnastics qualifier when her mutation surfaced mid-routine — a botched dismount that should have ended in a torn ACL instead ended with her bouncing off the mat, the floor, and a judges' table before she managed to stop herself, mostly unhurt and thoroughly disqualified. Competitive gymnastics doesn't have a division for kinetic energy manipulation, so that career ended the same day a very different one started.

She's a full-time student now, with the powers as an extremely loud after-school activity. The same instincts that made her a good gymnast — spatial awareness, fearlessness about falling, an internal clock for exactly when to commit to a move — translate directly, and she's never been shy about using them. She rewired an old WiFi router for the Community Center once as a favor to Circuit and has been a fixture there ever since, mostly because it's the one place her energy doesn't get her in trouble.

PERSONALITY

Dani talks fast, moves faster, and has never once successfully sat still through a full class period. She processes stress by making jokes, which serves her well in a crisis and less well at, say, a parent-teacher conference. Underneath the constant motion is a genuinely sharp read on people — she notices immediately when a friend's gone quiet in the wrong way, and she'll drop the bit instantly to check on them. She'd rather be liked than respected, though she usually manages both without meaning to.

TRAITS

Parkour Instinct. Former competitive gymnast reflexes, repurposed for city terrain. Rooftops, fire escapes, and tight alleyways are second nature to her.

Motormouth. Dani copes with pressure by talking through it. In a boardroom or a courtroom that same instinct reads as glib and undisciplined — but in the middle of a crisis, her running commentary is exactly what a rattled teammate needs to hear to refocus.

Watches Her People. She's the first to notice when someone at the table has gone quiet in the wrong way, and she never lets it go unaddressed.

POWERS

Kinetic Bolt. A concentrated burst of kinetic force thrown like a punch from a distance, striking anything unlucky enough to be standing in its path.

Overcharge Bolt. A far stronger version of the same trick — a bolt of raw kinetic energy powerful enough to send its target stumbling backward off their feet.

Kinetic Rebound. When a blow connects with her, Dani redirects the force of the impact, softening the hit and using the recoil to fling herself instantly out of harm's way.

Bounce Step. Any solid surface becomes a springboard — a wall, a dumpster, a parked car. Dani launches off of it to cover far more ground than a normal stride would allow, landing already primed to strike.



The Latch

Renata "Ren" Cruz

RENATA "REN" CRUZ · COMMUNITY CENTER SECURITY, NIGHT CLASSES IN CRIMINAL JUSTICE

HISTORY

Renata Cruz has no mutation, no accident, no cosmic ray — just a lot of deliberate, unglamorous training and a refusal to be the only unarmed person in a room full of people who can shrug off gunfire. She works security at the Wickfield Community Center by day, takes night classes toward a criminal justice degree, and spends the hours in between drilling with a pair of collapsible batons until the motion doesn't need thinking about anymore.

She's watched the Center's doors long enough to know its rhythms and its regulars better than anyone, which made her the natural person to notice when things started going wrong — the rolling blackouts, the sense that something was working its way toward the building block by block. Everyone else on the team got their abilities handed to them one way or another. Ren built hers, on purpose, one repetition at a time, and she's quietly proud of that fact even though she'd never say so directly.

PERSONALITY

Ren is stubborn in the specific, useful way that reads as reliability under pressure. She does not disengage from a problem once she's decided it's hers, does not like admitting she's overmatched, and has a backup plan for her backup plan as a matter of professional habit rather than anxiety. She takes the team's lack of respect for her nonpowered status as fuel rather than an insult — the batons and the training got her here, and she intends to keep proving that's enough.

TRAITS

Trained, Not Powered. Security work and criminal justice coursework both pay off the moment it's time to read a room or investigate a scene.

Doesn't Back Down. Ren has a hard time admitting she's overmatched, or walking away from a fight once she's decided it's hers.

Always Has a Plan B. She really does always have a plan B. When something she's tried falls apart, she's usually already got the next approach ready to go.

POWERS

Baton Strike. A precise strike from one of her collapsible batons, aimed to catch an opponent off guard rather than overpower them.

Accuracy. As long as she hasn't taken a hit yet in a fight, Ren's batons find their mark with uncanny reliability.

Fast Strikes. Two quick baton strikes thrown in the same motion, aimed at two different opponents standing close together.

Counterstrike Technique. When an opponent's blow misses her, Ren answers before they can recover, snapping a baton strike back at them in the same instant.



Wisp

Théo Bellamy

THÉO BELLAMY · BIKE COURIER

HISTORY

Théo Bellamy's power came on in the middle of traffic: a delivery run, a car that didn't see him, and then a very long, very strange half-second where the world slowed down enough for him to simply not be where the bumper was anymore. He walked away without a scratch and without any idea what had just happened, and it took him the better part of a month of increasingly reckless experimentation to understand he could do it on purpose.

Bike courier work turned out to be the perfect cover and the perfect training ground at once — nobody questions why the courier is fast, and the job pays him, however modestly, to spend all day doing the thing he can't stop wanting to do anyway. He knows Wickfield's streets, alleys, and shortcuts better than anyone, which made him the obvious choice when the Community Center needed someone to run point on moving fast for a good reason instead of a paycheck.

PERSONALITY

Théo is perpetual motion given a personality. He talks in run-on sentences, finishes other people's thoughts, and has never once been the one to suggest a break. Stillness is genuinely uncomfortable for him — stakeouts and waiting rooms are a special kind of torture — but that same restlessness makes him relentlessly upbeat and quick to volunteer for anything that involves moving right now. He shows up early to almost everything out of pure inability to idle, which the rest of the team has learned to rely on.

TRAITS

Courier's Eye. Years of courier runs have mapped Wickfield into his head better than any app ever could. He always knows the fastest way to get somewhere.

Can't Sit Still. Stillness doesn't come naturally to Théo. Stakeouts, interrogations, waiting rooms — anything that demands patience wears on him visibly.

Never Late. He is, categorically, never the last one to react when trouble starts.

POWERS

Blur Strike. Théo only needs a beat of momentum. Coming out of a sprint, he closes the last few feet in a blur and lands a strike before the target even registers he's moved, and he's already somewhere else by the time they do.

Rapid Volley. Two of those blurring strikes, thrown in the same heartbeat, against the same target or two different ones.

Quickness. His body never really stops accelerating. He acts and moves again in the same span of time it takes most people to manage either one.

Windbreak. He can read the path of an incoming projectile early enough to throw its aim off entirely, slipping out of the way before it ever arrives.